Vision Led Community ofChrist as an Agent of Transformation

By Richard Howell

The distinctiveness of the community of Christ is found in the radical and challenging nature of God's dynamic and transforming relationship with the people God has called to be His own. The Church is the people of God, the body and bride of Christ, and the temple of the Holy Spirit. The global Church is transnational, transcultural, trans-denominational and multi-ethnic family, the household of faith; and as we have discussed earlier that the community of Christ in a particular context also must reflect the multicultural reality of the body of Christ.

The church as a called community of God's people has a special responsibility – to be a sign, a foretaste, and an instrument of God's reign. This means, that the community points beyond itself to the coming reign of God. As a Spirit-filled community, church is to manifest the coming reign of God in its common life and shared ministry. The church, as a messianic community, is to participate in the actualization of the coming reign of God in the world as it works for fullness of life for individuals and justice in the society and healing for all creation.

The Challenge for the community of Christ is to be open to the power, the presence and the promise of God's vision of the future. The community as a whole need to discern together God's vision for the transformational mission.

Transformational mission does not require larger- than- life leaders at helm. Rather the fruitfulness of transformational mission lies in building the strength of the community as the primary way forward. How we think about the community of Christ is most important. People are always subjecting and never objects that is because of its belief that all followers of Christ are called children of God. The Church is in transformational mission with its members. This principle is difficult for many Churches, since so much of the history of church leadership has been patriarchal and paternalistic, with the leaders making every making decision for, people. As we have discussed earlier, Jesus said, his disciples are "salt, "light," "leaven," "loved." Persons are not objecting to be acted upon but subjects who act. They are gifted, creative, self-responsible subjects who are to be involved in the out working of the transformational mission.

One of the wondrous aspects of human life is the ability to remember the past and to analyze the present; we have the capacity to project ourselves into the future. It is because the community of Christ believes in "God of Hope" (Romans 15:13), a God who declares "See, I am making all things new" (Revelation. 21:5), that its vision can be hopeful and even imaginative Not limited by the facts, figures, and trends of the current situation, believing hope imagines a new state of affairs not yet existing.

We are given the ability to imagine –to visualize- God's dream for humanity: a time when the lion and the lamb will lie down together, when sword will be pounded into ploughshares, when war will be no more, when the captives will be freed and the blind will see, when the hungry will be fed and the naked clothed. In other word, when all of creation will be transformed into a new heaven and a new earth. The community of faith knows rather than human progress or development, it is God's freedom and God's faithfulness which is the source of the new things that are to come.

The cultivating of faithful imaginations is crucial for the community of Christ who in this life "walk by faith, not by sight (2 Corinthians 5:7). If we cannot imagine a time of fullness of life,

reconciliation and healing, when God will dwell with his people and 'wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death will be no more" (Revelation 21:3), then we are enslaved to our present experience of alienation and death and overwhelmed by poverty, suffering, and injustice of our world. Faithfulness is not only about submitting our wills in obedience, but also opening and trusting our imaginations in delight.

The community of Christ is not first a sociological entity but a theological experience – a joint participation in God's vision, reign, reality, world –which enables us to participate with one another in a fellowship of faith, hope, and love (cf. 1Corinthians 13:3). Because in Jesus Christ all that alienates us from God and divides us from one another has been overcome, the Holy Spirit is at work creating a reality of holy living, mutual support, and sacrificial service which the New Testament calls fellowship, challenging old competitive order of interdependence, shared responsibility, and mutuality.

While it is comforting to believe that Jesus died for our sins, the community of Christ in transformational mission must embrace the reality of the cross indicating the shape, direction, and destiny of the life and witness of the church: "take up your cross and follow me." The way of the cross- humility, sacrifice, rejection, persecution, and suffering, even unto death—does not market well in a consumer-oriented, "meet my needs" culture. In other words, cross is still a scandal and a folly within the dominant vision of our contemporary world. The community of Christ should not change its vision and ethical practices in response to the changes in the market society rather it should change markets to remain true to its vision.

In Jesus Christ God's promised future invaded the present. The raising of Jesus from the dead was an event of cosmic proportions; in the midst of the old creation of sin, darkness, and death, God inaugurated a new creation of forgiveness, light and life. The biblical image of new creation signifies not only a redeemed humanity, but a renewed earth, set free from its "bondage to decay" (Romans 8:21). The worldly forces of class privilege, economic advantage, environmental exploitation, gender domination, ethnic discrimination, absolute loyalty to family or nation that subvert and block the actualization of God's vision for God's creation have been unmasked, exposed, and disarmed (Colossians 2:15).

As the first fruits of God's new creation, the community of Christ visualizes and experiences God's transforming power the presence and peace of God in a whole new way. Transformational mission requires a major reorientation. That is, it requires new ways of perceiving, new ways of thinking, and new ways of behaving.

God's vision, God's truth, God's will, cannot be legislated by the political maneuvering of special interest groups, but only through prayer and in fellowship of the community which expects to hear and listen from the Spirit working with the Word and through the Word of God. It is within the context of community of Christ through the power of the Holy Spirit that we are formed and transformed by the Word for sacrificial engagement for transforming of the world. The vision of God clarifies the direction in which the community of Christ needs to move. The love of God poured love into our hearts by the Holy Spirit is the glue that will keep us together over time (Rom. 5:5).